

of what was a vernacular house-building tradition, stretching back thousands of years. Though they appear crude, they are ideally adapted to local conditions, and being made only of mud and straw, they can be repaired more or less indefinitely. Their most obvious advantage is that their thick walls are ideal for absorbing fierce desert heat during the day and reradiating it during what are often bitterly cold nights. The heat that does enter the structures is able to escape from the small opening at the summit of the cones, guarded by a sort of tiny chimney that prevents rain from getting in.

Shibam

Location Hadhramaut, Yemen

Shibam, on the edge of the fearsome Rub' al Khali ("Empty Quarter") desert, is one of the world's most extraordinary walled cities. Its buildings are a group of mud-brick high-rises clustered tightly together. Most are between five and eleven stories, and a few exceed 98 ft (30m). The city itself dates from the 3rd century CE, but most of the current buildings were built from the 16th century. Although they were painstakingly constructed, the buildings require

almost constant repair and have all been rebuilt many times. They are simple, rectangular structures that taper slightly as they rise. Smaller, lighter bricks are used for the upper floors, and the windows are small and square. The walls are whitewashed to reflect solar radiation and reduce heat gain.

Tomb of Jahangir

Location Lahore, Pakistan

The son of Akbar the Great, Jahangir, the fourth Mughal emperor of India, ruled from

1605 to 1627. His tomb is a prime example of the severity, regularity, symmetry, and delicacy of Mughal architecture as it approached its peak in the 17th century. It is a long and low square building, with four kiosk-topped minarets at its corners. It sits in the center of an immense walled garden courtyard. While the external appearance is severe, internally it is a precise expression of the Mughal empire's capacity to use astonishing decorative detail in its dynastic monuments. The tomb itself, under a commanding dome over the exact center of the complex, rests under a single slab of marble. On the tomb are inscribed the 99 names of God.



▲ RED SANDSTONE COURTYARD OF FATEHPUR SIKRI